day: or we would be late for the conference. Deshingkar shook his wise head and kept us in the queue. In twenty minutes, the bank clerk had dealt with all of us including helping the foreigners fill out various forms – and all this with cool courtesy. I left thinking about my bank back at Jawaharlal Nehru University. The little Shanghai bank was clean, subdued, and air-conditioned. My equally little Indian bank, populated by six or seven clerks and a chaiwalla boy, was paan-spattered, boisterous with bank officials and customers, and cooled by whirring ceiling fans. The banking modes and experiences were worlds apart.

Military Power

Military power is the second component of hard power. For most analysts of international security issues, it is the most important component, the 'sharp end of the stick'. Economic power is the basis in the long run for military power. That is why it is important to begin a relative power assessment with economic capacity. However, when the chips are down, military power counts. Compared to the enormous disparities in economic strength, India and China are not as far apart in military strength. Indeed, given the stopping power of the Himalaya and the maritime distances, the imbalance is less daunting. Having said that, relying on a strict numerical assessment and geography is misleading. Strategy – or how you deploy and use your forces – counts for a lot.

Ground Forces and Air Balance

Since the primary theatre of active military confrontation between India and China is the border, it is best to begin with the army and air balance. At last count, in 2020, according to the International Institute of Strategic Studies (IISS) in London, India's armed forces personnel numbered roughly 1.4 million as against China's 2 million. Of these, their armies accounted for 1.237 million and 975,000, respectively, the Chinese having downsized